Independent practice

Helping students begin and sustain effort

Use independent practice to build accurate, sustained performance after explanation and guided rehearsal. Plan the launch, first items and monitoring so students remain thinking throughout.

How to do it well

1 Prepare for success. Use evidence from guided practice to confirm that most pupils can complete the process accurately and identify who still needs a scaffold or teacher check.

2 Rehearse before release. Correct common misconceptions, make the success criteria visible and clarify what pupils should do if they become stuck.

3 Mirror before you leap. Begin with the same method, representation and type of material used in guided practice. Do not hide new knowledge inside an 'independent' task.

4 Monitor in motion. Circulate from the first item, sample the whole room and intervene before an error is repeated across the set.

5 Build fluency through repetition. Secure accuracy first, then reduce hesitation, increase volume or add carefully selected variation.

6 Connect to future retrieval. Return to the learning after a delay and mix it with related content so performance becomes durable and flexible.

What this sounds like

“Begin with the first two items independently. If stuck, identify the step that is unclear and use the model. When finished, explain why your method works.”

Classroom example. A teacher begins independent practice with two familiar items, clear success criteria and a taught stuck protocol. A short observation establishes the working norm before circulation. Early answers reveal one shared error, so the class receives a bounded repair. Pupils then return to productive practice with a meaningful explanation task for early finishers.

Top tips that make the technique work

Protect the first moments. A brief Golden Silence establishes the expectation before circulation begins.

Teach what to do when stuck. Students can check the model, identify the uncertain step or move to a permitted item; repeated hand-up waiting reduces participation.

Inspect the first attempt. Early diagnosis prevents a whole page of repeated errors.

Provide a meaningful finish task. Deepen the same learning through explanation or variation rather than unrelated extra work.

Preserve productive time. Interrupt only when a common issue makes the class pause worthwhile.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Check readiness before release.	Hiding new learning inside the independent task.
Use a route that includes the whole room.	Equating a quiet classroom with sustained thinking.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Require and Monitor Independent Practice | Barton - Participation during independent practice